Then we discovered we weren't free: the press had followed us the whole way and papped us outside Booley's house.

After a period of acclimatizing to the Firefly's cockpit, becoming familiar with the control panel, we finally took her up. On one of our first flights together, with no warning, Booley threw the aircraft into a stall. I felt the left wing dip, a sickening feeling of disorder, of entropy, and then, after several seconds that felt like decades, he recovered the aircraft and leveled the wings.

I stared at him. *What in the absolute—?*

Was this an aborted suicide attempt?

No, he said gently. This was the next stage in my training. Countless things can go wrong in the air, he explained, and he needed to show me what to do—but also how to do it.

Stay. Cool.

Our next flight, he pulled the same stunt. But this time he didn't recover the aircraft. As we went spinning and pirouetting towards Earth he said: *It's time.*

For what?

For YOU to…DO IT.

He looked at the controls. I grabbed them, stuck the boot in, regained the aircraft in what felt like the nick of time.

I looked at Booley, waited for congratulations.

Nothing. Barely any reaction at all.

Over time Booley would do this again and again, cut the power, put us into freefall. As the creaking metal and roaring white noise of the stilled engine became deafening he'd turn calmly to his left: *It's time.*

Time?

You have control.

I have control.

After I restored the power, after we returned to base safely, there was never any fanfare. Not even much chatter. No medals in Booley's cockpit for simply doing your job.